householders of the highest three ***castes***, in addition to observance of the obligations appropriate to one's ***caste*** and stage of life controls, maintains and perpetuates order and stability in the universe. A properly performed rite automatically produces its result. It does not depend upon a god. To account for cases where the rite is not observed to deliver its promised result, the *Mimamsakas* introduced a special form of supernatural causal power (*apurva*) belonging to properly performed ritual acts that brings about their results in the future.

Dharma is not a 'universal' ethic because its demands vary according to one's caste and stage of life. One and the same type of action might be right for one person (*sva-dharma* = 'own *dharma*') and wrong for another. There was a widespread recognition of the principle that it is better to perform one's own *dharma* badly than that of another well.

See ***Ahimsa***

Further reading: Halbfass 1991; Olivelle 1999; Sanderson 1985

Dharmakirti (600–60 CE): major Buddhist philosopher who agrees with ***Dignaga*** that objective reality is a flux of momentary unique particulars (***svalakshana***) that are inexpressible and incommunicable as such. Each has its own causal effectiveness (***arthakriya***). To be is to be causally effective. Each particular has specific location, time and form.

The ***svalakshanas*** are given in sensory perception (*pratyaksha*), which he defines as awareness that is free from concepts and that is reliable (***abhranta***). Sensory impressions are copied by images that are interpreted in concepts by a mind conditioned by its past experiences (***vasana***). So the external unique particulars are the indirect objects of thoughts. The unique instants behave in such a way that we can organise them under unifying